Lesson 13: Main Ideas, Support and Rhetorical Appeals

English Stage 3 (C1) · Unit 2: Critical Reading

Adapted from Reading, Writing, Research, and Reasoning: An Advanced ESL Text by Gabriel Winer and Elizabeth Wadell, ASCCC Open Educational Resources Initiative (CC BY-NC 4.0): 1.6: Finding Main Ideas and Support; 1.7: Finding Ethos, Pathos, and Logos.

In this lesson

You will find the topic, main idea and supporting details in a research article and a student essay, and identify the three rhetorical appeals: pathos, ethos and logos. At university, these skills help you ask of every article or lecture: What is the main claim? What supports it? How does the writer try to persuade me?

Learning goals

After this lesson you should be able to:

- Distinguish the topic, the main idea (thesis), supporting reasons and supporting details.
- Find the thesis and the topic sentences of an academic essay, and the main idea of an article.
- Separate major supporting details from minor ones.
- Identify pathos, ethos and logos in quotations and in a talk.
- Judge which appeals are most effective, and explain why.

Key language

Word or phrase	Meaning	Example
topic	a word or phrase that answers "What is the text about?"	undocumented immigrant rights; the problem with stereotypes
main idea / thesis	the most important point the writer makes about the topic	We can find the thesis at the end of the introduction.
thesis statement	1-3 sentences that show what the writer intends to prove; the controlling idea of an essay	A thesis statement drives an essay.
topic sentence	the first sentence of a body paragraph: an opinion that gives one reason for the thesis	Each body paragraph should begin with a topic sentence.
supporting reasons	points that explain the main idea and present facts	Supporting reasons explain the main idea.
supporting details	examples and other points that clarify a reason	Supporting details clarify the major reasons with examples.

Word or phrase	Meaning	Example
major / minor detail	a detail that directly supports the point / a smaller example that explains a major detail	Which ones seem to be major ones and which ones are minor ones?
rhetoric	the art of effective, persuasive writing and speaking	Writers and speakers use rhetoric to convince their audience.
rhetorical appeal	a method a writer or speaker uses to persuade	Aristotle called these three rhetorical appeals.
pathos	an appeal to emotions and values	stories, anecdotes (short personal stories), powerful words, images
ethos	an appeal to credibility and trust	experts with their credentials; accurate citations; first-hand testimony
logos	an appeal to logic and evidence	facts, case studies, experiments, statistics

Rules and explanations

Topic, main idea and support

First identify the topic, then the main idea; then check that the most important details explain the main idea. (Table 1.5.1 in the material.)

Element	What it is	Where to find it in an academic essay
Topic	a word or phrase: what is the text about?	the title and the introduction
Main idea (thesis)	the writer's most important point or message about the topic; all key information supports it; the title may give a clue	at the end of the introduction, usually 1-3 sentences
Supporting reasons	points that explain the main idea and present facts	the topic sentence at the start of each body paragraph: an opinion statement related to the thesis
Supporting details	examples and other points that clarify each reason	after each topic sentence; each paragraph focuses on one point and relates back to the topic sentence and the thesis

- In other kinds of text, such as magazine articles, the same elements exist, but in different places: paragraphs may be shorter, and the main idea may come later or be less directly stated.

The three rhetorical appeals

How do we know whom to trust? How do writers convince readers? The Greek philosopher Aristotle (384-322 BC) described three methods, or rhetorical appeals. Texts and talks often combine them. Academic writing emphasizes ethos and logos, but pathos can also be useful.

Appeal	The writer's goal	Techniques
Pathos (emotions and values)	convince the audience by appealing to their heart and emotions	stories, anecdotes, powerful words or phrases, images that awaken strong emotions such as anger, joy or fear, connected to people's beliefs
Ethos (credibility and trust)	build trust by presenting the argument thoughtfully and thoroughly, with expert opinion	introducing recognized experts with their credentials, citing sources accurately, first-hand testimony, appropriate language (for example, "This suggests ...")
Logos (logic)	develop the argument logically, with evidence we can measure, count or agree on	facts, case studies, experiments, statistics, logical reasoning and organization, defining key terms, explaining ideas, being objective

> **Note for Arabic speakers** - Arabic persuasive writing often relies on repetition, parallel structures and emotional emphasis. English academic writing relies more on logos and ethos: state the main idea directly, then support it with evidence and credible sources.

Practice

Exercise 1. Main idea and support in an article. Look back at "Undocumented Immigrants May Actually Make American Communities Safer – Not More Dangerous – New Study Finds" by Robert M. Adelman and Lesley Reid (Lesson 12 material, section 1.5).

1. What is the topic?
2. What is the main idea, and where is it?
3. What are the major supporting details that prove the main idea?

Exercise 2. Analyze a student essay. Read the first two paragraphs of "Following One's Dream", a student essay by Linh Tran on Reyna Grande's memoir *A Dream Called Home* (section 1.6). (The book says "work with a partner"; work alone, then discuss with your tutor.)

1. What topic(s) can you identify in the student essay?
2. What is the thesis statement (the main idea of her essay)?
3. What is the topic sentence? In other words, what is the main idea of the student's first body paragraph?
4. What supporting details does the student provide? Which ones seem to be major ones and which ones are minor ones?

Exercise 3. Identify the appeals. Jose Antonio Vargas came to the U.S. from the Philippines at 12 and found out at 16 that he was undocumented. He is a journalist, filmmaker and Pulitzer Prize winner. Read the three quotations from his book *Dear America: Notes of an Undocumented Citizen* in section 1.7.

1. Which appeal does quotation 1 use ("Later that night, on a phone call with Mama, ...")?
2. Which appeal does quotation 2 use ("Another editor, Ann Gerhart, ...")?

3. Which appeal does quotation 3 use ("Annually, undocumented workers pay 12 billion to the Social Security Trust Fund.")?
4. Which appeals are most effective for you? Why?

Exercise 4. Appeals in a talk. Watch Jose Antonio Vargas's TED talk "3 questions to ask yourself about US citizenship" (about 9 minutes; see Watch online). Find one example of each appeal. If you cannot watch the talk, use "Deport Me" by Alejandro Fuentes-Mena (Lesson 11 material, section 1.2) instead.

Speak with your tutor

- "Here are the topic, main idea and three supporting details I found in the Adelman and Reid article: [paste]. Is my main idea a full sentence that covers the whole text?"
- "Ask me which details in the second paragraph of 'Following One's Dream' are major and which are minor. Challenge my choices."
- "Give me six short quotations about psychology or education. I will say whether each one uses pathos, ethos or logos and explain why."
- "Take the role of a skeptical reader of 'Deport Me'. Tell me which appeal convinces you least. I will defend the text. After five turns, tell me which of my points were strongest."

Read aloud

1. Rhetoric is the art of effective, persuasive writing and speaking.
2. A thesis statement drives an essay. It is the controlling idea.
3. Undocumented immigration does not increase the violent crime rate in U.S. metropolitan areas.
4. In her memoir, we can see how she struggled to find a sense of belonging in the U.S. and achieve her dream.
5. Annually, undocumented workers pay 12 billion to the Social Security Trust Fund.
6. Word stress: RHET·o·ric, rhe·TOR·i·cal, PA·thos, E·thos, LO·gos, cre·DEN·tials, AN·ec·dote.

Writing task

A short analysis of rhetorical appeals. Write two paragraphs (180-250 words in total) about one text:

- Vargas's TED talk or "Deport Me";
- the editorial "A Win for Undocumented Immigrants is a Win for All" (Lesson 12 material);
- a psychology lecture: PSYC 110 Lecture 20, "The Good Life: Happiness", Chapters 3 and 4 (studies, examples and expert names).

Paragraph 1 (2-3 sentences): the author or speaker, the title, the topic and the main idea in your own words. Paragraph 2: one example of each appeal, with a short quotation or a precise description, and an explanation of how it persuades the audience. End with your judgment: which appeal is most effective, and why?

Checklist:

- Your first sentence names the author and the title; the main idea is in your own words.
- Each appeal is named correctly: pathos = emotions and values, ethos = credibility and trust, logos = logic and evidence.
- Each example is exact: quotations are copied word for word, in quotation marks.
- After each example, you explain how it persuades, not only which appeal it is.
- You end with a clear judgment and a reason.
- After the first mention, you use the writer's last name only.

Paste your draft into the chat and ask your tutor for feedback. Then rewrite it.

Watch online

- Jose Antonio Vargas, "3 questions to ask yourself about US citizenship" (TED, 2020): https://www.ted.com/talks/jose_antonio_vargas_3_questions_to_ask_yourself_about_us_citizenship

Answer key

Exercise 1

1. Undocumented immigration and crime in U.S. metropolitan areas.
2. Undocumented immigration does not increase violent crime in U.S. metropolitan areas, and it may reduce property crime. It is stated at the very beginning, under the heading "The big idea", not at the end of an introduction as in an academic essay. This is typical of a short research brief in a magazine.
3. (1) The authors' new study of 154 metropolitan areas, using two estimates of the undocumented population and FBI crime data, found that undocumented immigration, on average, has no effect on violent crime. (2) Its regression analysis showed that as the undocumented population increases, the property crime rate decreases, on average (for example burglary). (3) Earlier research agrees: the authors' 2005 analysis found that immigration did not increase crime; their 2017 study found less property crime in areas with more immigrants (1970-2010); and the new findings build on a 2018 review of 51 studies by Ousey and Kubrin.

Exercise 2

1. (example answer) Immigration to the U.S.; Reyna Grande's life and her memoir *A Dream Called Home*; an immigrant's struggle to belong and to achieve a dream (to become a writer). The student's own experience as an Asian immigrant is a minor topic.
2. "In her memoir, we can see how she struggled to find a sense of belonging in the U.S. and achieve her dream." It is the last sentence of the introduction. The sentence before it ("*A Dream Called Home* is about her hard life in the U.S.") introduces the book.
3. "Reyna felt like an outsider when she visited her country and wrote stories about her hometown which her creative writing teacher rejected." The paragraph's main idea: Reyna felt that she did not belong anywhere, in Mexico or in the U.S. This supports the "sense of belonging" part of the thesis.
4. (example answer) Major details: during ten days in Mexico she was heartbroken because people no longer saw her as Mexican, while in the U.S. people thought she was not American enough, so she felt she could not belong anywhere; her creative writing teacher rejected her stories about her hometown as "too outrageous" but loved her American classmates' stories; as the only Latinx student in the class at UCSC, she felt hopeless, thought about dropping out and questioned her dream. Minor details: the quotation about why she wrote the stories (74); the examples of her stories (the flood, with people on their roofs collecting dead animals in canoes; the barefoot girl hit for being left-handed); the topics of her classmates' stories (75). Note that the topic sentence joins two ideas (feeling like an outsider and the rejected stories); the book's table says a paragraph should focus on one point.

Exercise 3

1. Pathos (book). A personal story told with strong feeling: he learns that his "uncle" was a smuggler and that his suitcase had been packed for months. Readers share his shock.

2. Ethos (book). He names respected professionals, an editor "known for her keen journalistic eye" and "an ace fact-checker", who checked that all the facts were correct, so readers can trust his writing.
3. Logos (book). A statistic: a measurable amount (12 billion dollars a year) that readers can check.
4. (example answer) For an academic audience, quotation 3 is the most effective, because a number can be checked and is hard to argue with. For a general audience, quotation 1 may be more powerful, because readers remember stories and feel empathy.

Exercise 4 (example answer) In the TED talk:

- Pathos: the opening story: at 16, a clerk told him his green card was fake: "Don't come back here again." His grandfather, a security guard earning no more than eight dollars an hour, saved 4,500 dollars to bring him to America.
- Ethos: he presents himself as "a journalist and filmmaker"; he has asked his questions in front of diverse audiences across America; he quotes the writer Toni Morrison.
- Logos: historical facts and dates (for example, Native Americans were not considered U.S. citizens until the 1924 Indian Citizenship Act); facts about the citizenship test (officers ask up to 10 of 100 questions; applicants must answer at least six correctly); a clear structure built on three questions: "Where did you come from? How did you get here? Who paid?"

In "Deport Me":

- Pathos: his mother's weekend of work for 100 dollars ("She was priceless to me!"); "half-priced human beings".
- Ethos: the introduction gives his credentials (a BA in psychology, one of the first two DACAmented teachers through Teach for America, seven years of teaching); first-hand testimony.
- Logos: the numbers (contractors charge 20,000 dollars, his father asks 15,000 and receives about 10,000); "the billions in taxes we bring in every year"; the step-by-step "math lesson" structure.

My notes